Overview

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Written by: Nick Redgrove
Reviewed by: Deb Orrock
Updated on 3 October 2025

Stories of Ourselves Volume 2

In **Paper 1, Section B (Prose)**, you'll answer **one question on one story** from this selection. You'll choose between:

- A **passage-based question** (analyse how the writer creates effects in a printed extract)
- An **essay-style question** (explore a theme, character, or idea across the whole story)

You'll need to revise **all** the selected short stories because examiners can ask questions of any of the following ten short stories from the Stories of Ourselves anthology. Follow the links for dedicated revision notes on each of the stories:

Story No.	Story title	Author	Date
3	Nick	Christina Rossetti	1850
14	The Woman's Rose	Olive Schreiner	1899
26	The Black Ball	Ralph Ellison	1937
30	The Gold Watch	Mulk Raj Anand	1959
35	When It Happens	Margaret Atwood	1977
37	The Man Who Walked on the Moon	J.G. Ballard	1985
38	A Walk to the Jetty	Jamaica Kincaid	1985
40	Showing the Flag	Jane Gardam	1989
47	Haywards Heath	Aminatta Forna	2010

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

Summaries of each short story

Nick by Christina Rossetti

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
A man's envious wishes lead to transformations (sparrows, dog, stick, fire, old man) until he learns to be humble.	Envy, punishment and redemption, morality	Fairy-tale allegory, omniscient narrator with direct address, symbolism of transformations

Help me understand

The Woman's Rose by Olive Schreiner

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
A young woman recalls rivalry with another girl in a male-dominated settlement, ending in rare solidarity symbolised by a rose.	Patriarchy, rivalry versus sisterhood, solidarity, memory	Allegory, symbolism (rose, light and dark), reflective flashback structure

The Black Ball by Ralph Ellison

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
John, a Black janitor, reflects on his son's future, his union struggles, and the metaphorical "black ball" of exclusion.	Racism, injustice, fatherhood, hope for change	First-person narration, symbolism ("black ball"), irony, colour imagery

The Gold Watch by Mulk Raj Anand

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
Sharma is forced to retire after 20	Colonial exploitation,	Irony, symbolism (watch, Buick

hollow token of colonial “reward”.		narration

When It Happens by Margaret Atwood

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
Farm wife Mrs Burridge obsessively prepares for a vague disaster, torn between practicality and paranoia.	Fear, isolation, utopia versus dystopia, history and memory	Shifts in tense, symbolism (gun, fortress, food), cyclical ending

The Man Who Walked on the Moon by J.G. Ballard

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
A drifter befriends Scranton, who claims to be an astronaut, only to inherit his delusional identity after his death.	Identity, delusion versus reality, alienation, freedom	Unreliable first-person narrator, cyclical structure, irony, astronaut imagery as metaphor

A Walk to the Jetty by Jamaica Kincaid

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
Annie leaves Antigua for England, reflecting critically on family, colonial upbringing, and her own independence.	Adolescence, colonial identity, rebellion, migration	First-person subjective narration, irony, symbolism (jetty, sea)

Showing the Flag by Jane Gardam

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
Young Philip travels alone to France, clinging to a Union Jack as a symbol of	Family separation, cultural identity, childhood	Irony, symbolism (flag, suitcase, food), dialogue shaping misunderstanding

Haywards Heath by Aminatta Forna

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
Attila visits his old love Rosie in an English care home, only to find her lost to dementia.	Memory, lost romance, past versus present, diaspora identity	Omniscient narration, symbolism (Jaguar car, sweets), nostalgic imagery, pathos

Fluke by Romesh Gunesekera

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
Taxi driver Vasantha contrasts his modest business and peace of mind with a businessman's obsession with status and technology.	Tradition versus modernity, illusion versus reality, nature versus artifice	First-person monologue, humour, symbolism (sea, phone, "good chi"), irony

Tips for success

- Read the question carefully and highlight the **key words**
- Use **precise quotations** (short phrases or single words) to support points
- Focus on the **writer's choices** of language, structure, and form
- Avoid just retelling the story — always link back to the question
- Write a short plan, keep responses structured, and end with a **personal response** to the text

Teacher only

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Test yourself

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